

two-stroke engines and the bureaucracy says that the four-stroke snow scooter now on offer is a new vehicle and hence must go through the entire acquisition process. This could take between three to five years. There is of course no Fernandes to push for their replacement.

Now, nearly two decades later, the army is fighting to replace the improvised 1 kg helmet with a lightweight bulletproof one that offers all round protection. But the infantryman is unlikely to get these new helmets in a hurry. The older helmets cost Rs 400, the new ones cost Rs 6,000. Government rules prohibit anything more than a 10 per cent increase in the cost for a replacement. The case is still pending.

How does the field army cope with such crippling shortages? One battalion commander says he regularly dips into unit funds to buy equipment like boots for his men. "When we tell our seniors about the state of equipment, the response is the same: 'don't worry, it's the same across the army.' In fact, we are advised to just buy what we need from the open market instead of relying on the system." To bypass the system, the army introduced special financial powers for its commanders a decade ago. Now, even critical equipment like drones and night vision devices are being picked up through these special financial powers.

What then are the long-term implications of this systemic failure? Military analysts see ominous signs of this phase of the army reminiscent of the pre-1962 era of drift when the Indian Army was caught unprepared—no modern rifles or high altitude clothing—by the Chinese Army. While India's defence budget is just \$30 billion, that of China is estimated to be in the region of \$139 billion. In its White Paper of 2006 which lays the roadmap for its military build-up, the Chinese military projects the ability to defeat regional adversaries (India, Taiwan and Vietnam) by 2010. The Chinese claim to have already achieved this stage. Current internal projec-

## Pending Protection

Even basic gear is held up in procurement procedures

### 3.89 LAKH BALLISTIC HELMETS

DATE: FIRST PROPOSAL IN 2005

STATUS: MoD says at Rs 6,000 each, it is expensive



### LIGHTWEIGHT BULLETPROOF JACKET

DATE: FIRST PROPOSED IN 2007

STATUS: Order for 8,000 sent. Order for 1.81 lakh pending.



### 30,634 GEN III NIGHT VISION DEVICES (NVD)

DATE: PROPOSAL FLOATED IN 2006

STATUS: Case frozen last year after faults detected



### 84 MM ROCKET LAUNCHER AMMUNITION

DATE: PROPOSAL FOR 50,000 ROUNDS IN 2007

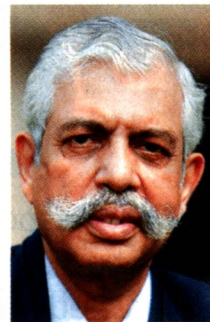
STATUS: Pending approval



## "THERE IS THE DIRE NEED TO MATCH THE TIMELINES

AND PACE OF OUR ACQUISITIONS WITH THAT OF OUR ADVERSARIES. THESE CANNOT BE VIEWED IN ISOLATION."

MAJOR-GEN. (retd) G. D. BAKSHI



tions of the Indian Army say it will be ready to address a 'two-front war' against China and Pakistan only by 2025. At current acquisition rates of under 50 per cent per five-year plan and

## Post-26/11 Go Slow

In December 2009 the army proposed to fast track the purchase of Rs 600 crore worth of urban combat counter-terrorism equipment. This included gas masks, bulletproof jackets, sub-machine guns, sniper rifles, helmets, fibrescopes, cornershots, see-through-wall radars and door-bursting grenades. A year later, only the grenades have been acquired. The rest will take at least 18 months to arrive.

obsolescence of weapons, even this date is far from being reached, analysts say. "There is the dire need to match the timelines and pace of our acquisition with that of our primary adversaries. These cannot be viewed in isolation," says Major-General G. D. Bakshi (retired).

The bigger problem, as an officer says, is that the shortfalls are now so well known within the army that nobody cares anymore. "Shortages do not even figure in our annual inspections. They are treated as a given. The *chalta hai* (anything goes) attitude has set in," an officer says. A dangerous attitude for an arm that has its mettle tested ever so often. ■